

KF11 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

During the past few weeks, we have been learning the **Maranatha Meditation**.¹ Try to practice this meditation in the morning and again later in the day; then, when faced with life’s problems, you will already be trained to step back and find your center. You will have the skill to be able to collect yourself and connect to God. Put a memo on your phone or on your daily schedule as a reminder to practice.

This month we will learn a new meditation practice called the **SALT Process**. I designed this tool to help members explore stressful events. You cannot cast your real fears onto God if you avoid knowing what those fears are. The **SALT Process** will help you examine your fears and cast your cares onto Him.²

The SALT Process

1. S is for Skin

Let’s begin with the mindfulness posture. Lift the top of your head toward the heavens and plant your feet or tailbone on the earth. Let your shoulders hang from that upright structure. Breathe. *(Pause)* Focus your mind on your body as the breath moves in and out. *(Pause for 20 seconds)* Notice where your skin is. Simply notice it. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Now, gather your attention to observe only what is within your own skin. If your mind wanders outside your skin—into the future, the past, a problem, or toward someone else—gently guide your mind back to what is happening in *your* body within *your* skin. Observe your experience without judgment, and breathe for thirty seconds. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. A is for Assess

Bring to mind an event or an outcome that you have judged as evil. If you can’t recall anything, think of something good and try to imagine what the lack of that thing would be like. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* As you consider this bad or evil situation, assess on a scale of one to ten how uncomfortable you are about it. An assessment of ten would mean that you feel very distressed and have judged the situation as very bad. Observe how your body feels. Is there fatigue, tension, or restlessness? *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Where in your body do you feel these things? *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Continue to breathe and observe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

If you find that the tension or discomfort in your body is too uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting. After taking a breath or two, respectfully return to the area that is reacting. Try using a long exhaling breath or a sigh to help your body process what you are feeling. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. L is for Look

Look for the fear behind the judgment. What makes the situation so uncomfortable? You might explore the sensations in your body and ask yourself: *What frightens me about this situation? (Pause) Is my freedom threatened? (Pause) Will this situation cause suffering for myself or for others? (Pause) Does this situation interfere with my pride system or my search for glory? (Pause) How might this situation stir up self-hate?* Ask God to help you identify your fear. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Step back from your assessment of the event as good or evil and just look at the fear that drives that assessment. Part of your training is to learn to simply observe your fear. Fear brings you valuable information. *(Pause)* You might try welcoming the fear. Thank the fear for what it tells you about your Idol Self and for how it motivates you to train toward freedom from fear. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

4. T is for Tell

Tell God about your fear. Tell Him about your Idol's terror and how enslaved you are to fear. Ask Him to help you learn how to overcome your fear by directing your energy toward love. Fear is often based on lies and illusions, so you might ask God to tell you the truth about what you fear. Then, explore your fear with His guidance, and continue to breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

And now, bring yourself back into co-respondence with your environment, that which is outside your skin. Allow what is within you to calmly observe and respond to what is without. Rest, and take a few deep breaths. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

I won't offer a hymn or prayer right now. Let's spend a moment just appreciating the effort we have made to learn a new practice. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we will begin exploring KF Confession 3:

We constructed legal systems based on our own assessment of good and evil.

I hope that you have the **Two Paths Worksheet** in front of you. This worksheet helps you see how powerful you are. We learn that our choices create outcomes. Outcomes do not appear by magic. *You* make them happen. You are a very powerful creature, and you can create a glorious life. You can also create your own misery. It really is your choice.

How do we create a glorious life? I'm so sorry to say it, but painful mistakes are part of that process. We cannot possibly know it all, be prepared for it all, foresee it all, and always protect our pride. In KF, we are learning to respond to our mistakes like little children. Little children don't react to their mistakes with

hurt pride, judgment, and self-hate. Although a child's outcomes may not meet our standards of perfection, little children are actually fulfilling their design. They are on a journey of discovery and learning to interact with the real world. We do not blame the child for falling when it tries to walk. Instead, we applaud the child for each step it takes. We are much easier on the child when it makes mistakes than we are on ourselves. We have learned to motivate ourselves by judgment and fear, so when we make mistakes, we are flooded with self-hate and overreact to restore our pride. Children motivate themselves with a sense of wonder and adventure. When they make a mistake, they don't beat themselves up with self-hate and judgment. Instead, they use their wonderful energy to learn. They take responsibility for their mistakes by trying something new and finding out what works.

We know that we are in pride and self-hate when we avoid taking responsibility for our mistakes by blaming, escaping, or making up virtue stories. When pride and self-hate are driving you toward misoriented reactions and destructive outcomes, the **Two Paths Worksheet** can help you untangle the mess you have made and guide you into the path of love. You really can learn to build new outcomes in your life.

Let's look together at steps 1–6 in the right-hand column of the worksheet under Judgment. I am going to use the example of my own experience to help you learn how to use this worksheet.

1. Outcome

You can begin your journey through this worksheet at any point, but often when trying to untangle a process that has resulted in anxiety, misery, or a mess, you have to begin with the outcome. This is probably an outcome that you did not want, or it could be an outcome that your Idol wanted very badly. You know that an outcome is misoriented when it does not reflect the Fruit of the Spirit; it is not glorious, and it falls short of the glory of God in your life.³ Let's begin by looking at the outcome of one of my messes and see how I got there. I was making chaotic decisions based on fear, and as James puts it, I was tossed around like the surf of the sea.⁴ I was double-minded and unstable in all my ways. The quality of my outcome told me that quite recently I had taken the Judgment Path.

2. Action

You might now ask the question: *What did I do or avoid that produced this outcome?* As a self-effacing neurotic, I acted by instantly following the advice of someone who had just given me distressing information. I started making decisions before breathing, praying, meditating, or getting counsel. Self-effacing types need to affirm their inferiority by pleasing others, seeking validation from others, and even inviting others to punish them. I am sorry to say, but there are many people, businesses, and institutions that will try to scare you into doing what they want you to do. We end up doing what they say or rebelling against them, but neither of these reactions comes from our True Self. Sometimes, if we already trust a person, it is not misoriented to immediately follow their advice, but most often I find that waiting and getting a second opinion helps me stay oriented.

3. Rejoicing in the misorientation

This step invites you to explore the emotions that may have compelled you to act. The Idol Self must defend its neurotic illusions to maintain its pride system. When those illusions are threatened, the Idol will seek to save its life by generating compelling emotions that drive misoriented reactions. In my case, I was feeling intimidated. Self-effacing types need to imagine and focus on evidence that proves how weak and helpless they are. Mastery types need to imagine evidence that supports the illusion that they are blameless, right, in control, and have it all figured out. When that illusion is threatened, they feel rage, revenge, acute anxiety, and contempt. Resigned types try to maintain the

illusion that they are free to do as they please, without any adverse consequences. When they feel disappointed, restricted, resentful, fatigued, or locked down, they use these emotions to justify their dash for freedom. In fact, feeling any strong emotion may frighten resigned people into withdrawing from or even rejecting life. All Idol types, however, can feel defensive, irritable, and unfairly treated, or they may simply go cold when their pride system is threatened.

4. Story

What story have you invented to explain why the situation is good or bad? Your story explains your fear and provides you with a seemingly logical motive for your reactions. We invent these imagined stories, which I call *virtue stories*, to justify the emotions that compel us to act. These stories make our misoriented emotions, judgments, and choices seem virtuous, realistic, and of moral value.

Self-effacing types will tell the story that other people have more to offer than they do. They believe that they are inferior to others and always feel that they need support. They see themselves as victims and feel like losers, and they tell themselves that other people are just smarter, more attractive, stronger, better educated, or more successful than they are. Mastery types tell stories that they hope will demonstrate their own superiority. They must imagine that others are competitive, offensive, or stupid in order to justify their overweening ambition to win or beat others down. They resist showing mercy or covering for someone because it feels too much like weakness. It's excruciating for mastery types to allow others to see their weakness, and that's why KF meetings can be very uncomfortable for them. When resigned types feel that their freedom is threatened by events, by others, or by their own feelings, they tell the story that something or someone is manipulating, coercing, or imposing on them. They judge imposition, change, or real emotion as bad. Their story helps them rationalize their choice to stonewall, push back, or escape. Resigned types find it extremely hard to be in training because they are so caught up in pursuing freedom from their immediate restrictions. Training to acquire real skills imposes necessary restrictions, and this feels loathsome to the resigned type. So, since much of life presents training opportunities, resigned types end up avoiding much of life.

5. Judging as good or evil

You are now ready to look at the judgment that you have made. Is this event good or evil? Has it supported or threatened your search for glory?

6. The fear of death and euphoria

Judgments are fueled by the fear of death, especially the death of our pride and dreams. This fear is experienced differently by each Idol type. The chapters in the book *Neurosis and Human Growth* that illustrate your Idol type will help you identify your particular fear of death.⁵ I have given you a few examples in this lesson, but I encourage you to study your Idol type carefully as this will help you to see clearly what you actually fear and what compels you to save your life. Remember that euphoria, or the escape from the fear of death, also sets us on the Judgment Path. When we feel euphoria, we cannot just observe what is. Instead, we judge the event as good and invest it with all kinds of hopes for our Idol's glory; the event has temporarily relieved us from our fear of death, and our pride has been restored.

Once you have worked through steps 1–6, you can use the **FAITH Process** to help you unload your fear of death. In the months to come, you will learn more ways to unload the burden of your fear. No one else can do that for you, and yet we often want others to take responsibility for our fear and unload the burden for us. I want to remind you again that Karis Fellowships is not a need-based ministry. It is an effort-based ministry. Changing your life is no one's responsibility but yours, and it is truly unfair to expect others to

make that effort for you. KF tools empower you to accomplish your own work, and it certainly will require work to plan and attend meetings, ask questions, get help in using the tools, review the teaching notes, and support the ministry. It takes effort to unload your fear. Unloading my fear is my business, and unloading your fear is your business.

After you have made an effort to unload your fear, you might use your glorious imagination to take the Believe It Path of the left-hand column. Rather than judging something as good or bad, just believe what has happened. State what *is*. Imagine what the story might be if you could lay your judgments aside. What have you learned about yourself, others, or life? What action might you take based on what you have learned? Talk with your Karis Link and enlist the imagination of others to help you. When you learn to take the Believe It Path, God will finally have the chance to show you what marvelous things He can do.

Next week, we will begin to learn the difference between my business, another's business, and God's business. If we cannot recognize our business, then our business is neglected and God's purposes are forestalled. When we recognize our business, we are able to weed out many of our strong reactions and learn to observe what is going on around us with calm composure and without judgment. Confidence comes from knowing our own business and tackling it with courage, endurance, and training, using all our skills and our KF tools. Our business is to develop our True Self so that the glory of God can be expressed through our lives. Another person's development is their business. Everything else is God's business.

This week, you might try exploring one of your misoriented outcomes using the **Two Paths Worksheet**. Think of your major fears. Could one of them be driving your judgment?

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, teach me to take responsibility for my own fears. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Let's look further at KF Confession 3:

We constructed legal systems based on our own assessment of good and evil.

We will now return to the letter from James and look at chapter 1 again. We learned that having our faith or trust tested is essential for our growth. If we want to grow, we will welcome life's events because they show us whether we are putting our trust in God or in the Idol Self. In our KF training we apply the Apostle John's idea of the *day of judgment* to our everyday life events.⁶ These events take us into a courtroom of examination where the truth about our souls is revealed. James uses different imagery and calls these events *experiments*, as in a laboratory.⁷ These experiments reveal the nature and quality of our trust.

God brings into our lives people and situations that stir up areas that need examination and healing. One of these areas is the area of wealth. We can be rich in money, skill, time, health, natural gifts, relationships,

and antecedents. We can also be poor in any of those areas. Our tendency is to judge wealth or poverty as good or evil.

This is my paraphrase of **James 1:9–12**.

⁹To the siblings of small resources, rather than feeling shame, let them proclaim their trust from their high place of living within limitations. ¹⁰The wealthy can proclaim their trust by refusing to use their resources to circumvent their limitations; they can choose to live as lowly creatures, because the reality is that the wealthy are subject to decay, just like a flower of the grassland. ¹¹For we know that the sun rises with burning heat that withers the grass; its flower falls, and its attractive façade is utterly destroyed. Even so, while going along in his or her way, the person of large resources will also fade away, just like all creatures. ¹²Favored is the one who endures life's experiments, whatever their circumstances may be, so that being approved as genuine and trustworthy that one will receive the crown of life, which God has promised to those who are loving Him.

Take a deep breath.

God has told us that this world is passing away, and when we judge wealth or poverty as good or evil, we are not seeing things from God's perspective.⁸ We often judge wealth as good because we perceive wealth as the absence of limitations. What bliss for the Idol Self to be free from limitations! We may also be attached to the idea of wealth, whether in terms of money, abilities, education, health, security, appearances, family, friends, or anything else, because it provides the illusion of effortless superiority. Our Idol then develops an attachment to wealth as a desirable and even necessary thing. Poverty might be defined as an extremely limited lifestyle. The limitations imposed by poverty or loss of wealth do not allow our Idol to feel superior or free, and this may be why we fear poverty in others; when we feel compelled to rescue or to judge others who are poor, we may actually be externalizing our own fear of poverty. For the Idol, what is particularly evil about poverty is the fact that it is full of limitations.

Perhaps we find ourselves stuck in poverty in some area of our lives. We may even choose not to access real resources because having resources is taboo, and we need to feel poor. We then use our perceived poverty to justify the demands we make on others. In our minds, poverty entitles us to what others have and relieves us of responsibilities—and we can always use it as an excuse for our underdevelopment. We might even enjoy a sense of superiority because in our poverty we see ourselves as unselfish, non-materialistic, or the underdog. Many impoverished people believe that their situation is special and that, therefore, they are entitled to special care.

We may feel compelled to judge others just because they are rich. Their wealth and apparent success reminds us of what we might do if we weren't flawed or if we made the same effort. Our sense of inferiority then stirs up our self-hate. We might fear wealth in general because it seems to make people into monsters. Judging wealth as bad then helps us feel superior and justifies our vindictive triumph.

When our identity is wrapped up in wealth or poverty rather than in the love of God, we believe that we deserve accommodation from others and from life. This attachment to accommodation creates anxiety and makes us vulnerable to disappointment and resentment. When we are not accommodated, our sense of significance and self-worth is threatened, and our pride is hurt. In our search to fulfill our imagined glory, we have put our trust in some kind of wealth or in the superiority of entitlement, and when those things elude us, we feel cheated.

James warns us that when we attach to something as vulnerable as the grass, which is passing away, we set ourselves up for all kinds of disappointments. Fear of loss stagnates our lives and numbs our creativity, driving us into all kinds of misorientation and resulting in more disappointment and loss. We live in a world that is passing away, but we are depending on it for our joy. How crazy is that? As eternal creatures, we just weren't designed to attach to this material world.

I knew a woman who was caught up into a spiritual place where she met a friend who had died. She had a lengthy conversation with that friend. When she expressed her concern about disappointment, he looked at her, so puzzled, and asked, "What is disappointment?" He honestly did not know. His question, and her inability to explain disappointment to an eternal being, opened her eyes to a dimension of spiritual peace unknown to her before. That conversation changed her life. She realized that she too was an eternal being and that she might as well let go of her disappointments today.

Humble circumstances, or poverty in some area, can be glorious because people with fewer resources are invited to develop more trust in God. These people learn to be grateful for everything. They learn to live with more limitations. They are highly motivated to change their lives. Their hunger is stronger than their fear.

James teaches us quite a bit about wealth in his letter. He's not against wealth, but he is against how we use wealth to support the Idol Self. The wealthy—those who are rich in money, abilities, possessions, family background, or experiences—are to glory in humiliation by choosing to participate in the limitations experienced by the rest of the world. They can take part in activities that put them in the place of a learner, and they can acknowledge their position as fellow creatures by demonstrating trustworthiness and active kindness. They too will need to explore their co-response with their Creator, even though they may appear as gods in our culture, which worships them and at the same time treats them with scornful envy. They must circulate gifts *in proportion to their resources*, or else their souls will stagnate into fear and self-hate.

In both poverty and wealth, persevering in the development of the True Self is the key to success. Through persevering in this process, we gain practical experience both in the world and in our relationship with God. You might share with the group evidence of your growth. If your Idol tends toward mastery, share with the group your experiments in humility, your areas of helplessness, and your vulnerability. If you are resigned, share how you are allowing others or life to impose limitations or possibilities on you. If your Idol tends toward self-effacement, speak openly about your accomplishments. Practice venturing into the taboo areas of your Idol Self. Sharing our practical experience grows our self-confidence and gives us greater authority in whatever socio-economic mission field we are designed to serve. Who gives us the stamp of approval when we persevere in the development of the True Self? Certainly God, but we too can approve the outcomes of an oriented life.

I hope that you will experience both poverty and wealth in many areas of your life, and at different times. Poverty can cleanse and prune the soul, while wealth can support more opportunities for exploration and service—after all, the wealthiest man who ever lived was Jesus. Your goal is to be complete and lack nothing. By running your race with endurance, whether in poverty or in wealth, you are learning to wear your crown of life, in this life, with authority and love.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, teach me to glory in both poverty and wealth. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe.
(Pause for 10 seconds)

Here is our integration focus: *Consider an area of poverty or wealth in your life. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few phrases that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider an area of poverty or wealth in your life*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings, or lack of feelings, without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush feelings or thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Breathe and hold your experience up to the light as you *consider this area of poverty or wealth in your life*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider poverty or wealth in your life*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what deprivation and envy or what security and abundance feel like in your body. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this area of poverty or wealth in your life*. Do you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you judge poverty or wealth as good or evil, as a liberty or a threat? What are your reasons? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Is this judgment a regular pattern in your life? Does your family culture or early training influence your judgments? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something—of the not-knowing, of responsibility, or of someone taking advantage of you? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created us to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you feel when they have *considered poverty or wealth*. You are a human creature and are not alone

in your feelings. *(Pause)* Feelings are just chemical reactions in your body bringing you information. With training, you can choose what you will do with those feelings. *(Pause)* You can observe and learn something from what you have just experienced. When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. Breathe with compassion for yourself and for anyone who mindfully encounters the challenges of poverty and wealth. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:27 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time together to train and heal. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You continue to guide us to our real glory and to the truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design. Help us to circulate with our community, with the rest of the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ John Main, *Monastery without Walls: The Spiritual Letters of John Main*, ed. Laurence Freeman (London: Canterbury Press Norwich, 2006), 32.

² 1 Pet. 5:7.

³ Gal. 5:22–23.

⁴ James 1:6.

⁵ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

⁶ 1 John 4:17.

⁷ James 1:2.

⁸ 1 John 2:7.